

Post-incident review PIR-2026-002

Mobile Backend: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 26 March 2026, Mobile Backend experienced stale data shown to users in production (AU East) for about 12 minutes. A developer in another team noticed their integration tests failing against the service. Investigation found that a race condition in the session cache returned tokens belonging to expired sessions.

Impact

Users of Mobile Backend saw stale data shown to users for about 12 minutes. The service owner, Mobile Engineering, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:13 First signal received.
- 09:38 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:59 Likely cause identified.
- 10:18 Mitigation applied.
- 10:46 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a race condition in the session cache returned tokens belonging to expired sessions.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

It took time to work out which team owned the affected component.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Load test the service at twice the expected peak before the next campaign.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Move certificate renewal into the automated rotation pipeline.